

Problem Set 1

POLS W4732

Fall 2026

Due September 11 before the TA section

Artificial-intelligence policy. Unless an exercise explicitly states otherwise, students may not use generative-AI systems (including ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, or AI-generated search answers) to formulate, derive, solve, explain, or write answers to this problem set. Course materials, ordinary calculators, typesetting software, the teaching team, and collaboration within the registered problem-set group are permitted. Any approved computational tool must be disclosed. Every group member is responsible for understanding and being able to explain the entire submission.

Exercise 1 (Augmented matching pennies). *Two students submit different formalizations of the augmented matching-pennies game from class. Student A includes only actions chosen at nodes that are reached in equilibrium. Student B includes a complete contingent plan for every decision node but assigns payoffs directly to actions rather than action profiles.*

1. Identify every error in each formalization.
2. Provide the smallest corrections needed to obtain a valid strategic-form game.
3. Write the corrected player set, strategy sets, and payoff functions.
4. Change one feature of the verbal description so that the players no longer have equally many pure strategies, and formalize the resulting game.

Exercise 2 (Iterated deletion). *Consider the game below, except that Player 1's payoff at (D, R) is the parameter $x \in \mathbb{R}$.*

		Player 2	
		L	R
Player 1	U	2, 1	-1, 2
	M	0, 3	0, 1
	D	-1, -2	x , -1

Characterize, for every x , the actions that survive iterated deletion of strictly dominated pure actions. For each region, give a deletion certificate: name the deleted action, the action that dominates it, and the relevant inequalities. Evaluate the claim that the answer is unchanged if “strictly” is replaced by “weakly,” and exhibit any difference in the surviving game.

Exercise 3 (Generalized Rock–Paper–Scissors). A win with Rock, Paper, or Scissors is worth r , p , or s , respectively; a loss is worth -1 , and a tie is worth zero. Assume $r, p, s > 0$.

		Player 2		
		R	P	S
Player 1	R	0, 0	$-1, p$	$r, -1$
	P	$p, -1$	0, 0	$-1, s$
	S	$-1, r$	$s, -1$	0, 0

Derive the completely mixed equilibrium and verify that every probability is positive and sums to one. Determine what happens as $r \rightarrow 0$. A proposed solution claims that a more valuable winning action must be played more often. Evaluate the claim and explain the strategic logic.

Exercise 4 (The Calvert–Wittman model). Two policy-motivated candidates have ideal policies 0 and 1 and choose platforms in $[0, 1]$. The representative voter’s ideal point is $m \in (0, 1)$. The closer platform wins; an exact tie is awarded to candidate L with probability $\tau \in (0, 1)$.

1. Write both payoff functions $u_L(p_L, p_R)$ and $u_R(p_L, p_R)$ explicitly, including all tie cases.
2. A proposed proof claims that m is a strictly dominant platform for both candidates. Identify the invalid step.
3. Characterize the pure-strategy Nash equilibrium set as a function of (m, τ) .
4. State whether your conclusion changes if the platform space is $\mathbb{R}$.

Exercise 5 (The ultimatum game). Two players divide a unit surplus. Player 1 offers Player 2 a share $x \in X_N = \{0, 1/N, \dots, 1\}$. Player 2 accepts or rejects. Acceptance gives payoffs $(1 - x, x)$; rejection gives (d_1, d_2) , where $d_1 + d_2 < 1$. Characterize all subgame-perfect equilibria for arbitrary N , paying attention to the responder’s behavior when indifferent. Study the limit as $N \rightarrow \infty$ and explain why replacing the grid by $[0, 1]$ can affect existence or uniqueness at a boundary.

Exercise 6 (The first-mover (dis-)advantage). For each of the sequential matching-pennies, Cournot–Tullock, and Hotelling–Downs models from class, construct the follower’s complete best-response correspondence before solving for the leader’s action. For the model assigned to your group, change the indicated primitive (contest decisiveness, marginal effort cost, or voter location). Determine whether the first mover is advantaged, disadvantaged, or neither relative to simultaneous play. Identify the feature of the follower’s response that produces the comparison and a parameter value at which the conclusion changes, or explain why it never changes.

Exercise 7 (Optional: expected utility under mixing). In the India–Pakistan Prisoner’s Dilemma from class, use the well-formed mixed strategy profile $\sigma_{IND}(Nuke) = 0.3$, $\sigma_{IND}(\neg Nuke) = 0.7$, $\sigma_{PAK}(Nuke) = 0.7$, and $\sigma_{PAK}(\neg Nuke) = 0.3$. A proposed solution considers only diagonal outcomes. Explain the error, write the full distribution over action profiles, verify that it sums to one, and compute both expected payoffs. Find the derivative of each expected payoff with respect to India’s probability of choosing Nuke and interpret its sign as a best-response statement.